DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

3.2 Voices Against Slavery

Abolitionists relied on shocking testimonials and appeals to good conscience in their fight to end slavery. They dared to write and publish newspaper articles to condemn the injustices of slavery. Others marshalled their strength to stand on a stage and share the indignities they had witnessed or personally endured.

In the first issue of the *The Liberator*, William Lloyd Garrison called slavery "America's all-conquering sin." He wrote, "I do not wish to think, or to speak, or write, with moderation. . . . I will not equivocate . . . I will not excuse . . . I will not retreat a single inch . . . AND I WILL BE HEARD!" Garrison also helped to found the American Anti-Slavery Society, members of which appear at a convention in New York in this 1850 photo. He would ally with women and men, African American and white, and wealthy and poor in his decades-long fight against slavery.

CRITICAL VIEWING What do you notice about the individuals gathered for a photo at this convention?



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DOCUMENT ONE

Primary Source: Speech from "Address to the Slaves of the United States," by William Lloyd Garrison, 1843

When William Lloyd Garrison published this speech in *The Liberator*, slavery had long been the basis for the southern economy. Garrison's passion for the abolitionist cause is evident in the way he addresses enslaved people directly.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE How does Garrison describe enslaved people, and what specific actions does he encourage them to take?

> We advise you to seize every opportunity to escape from your masters, and, fixing your eyes on the North Star, travel on until you reach a land of liberty. You are not the property of your masters. God never made one human being to be owned by another. Your right to be free, at any moment, is undeniable; and it is your duty, whenever you can, peaceably to escape from the plantations on which you are confined, and assert your manhood.

DOCUMENT TWO

Primary Source: Speech from "On the Injustice of Slavery," by Sojourner Truth, 1856

Sojourner Truth dictated her life story to Olive Gilbert for her book *Narrative of Sojourner Truth, a Northern Slave,* published in 1850. In the following address to the Friends of Human Progress, Truth shares her grief over the loss of her children. Her story provided clear evidence of the ongoing mistreatment of vast numbers of people who were unable to care for their children or even keep them from being sold.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE How does Truth's account reflect the lack of basic freedom enslaved people endured?

> I want to know what has become of the love I ought to have for my children? I did have love for them, but what has become of it? I cannot tell you. I have had two husbands, but I never possessed one of my own. I have had five children and never could take one of them up and say, "My child" or "My children," unless it was when no one could see me.

DOCUMENT THREE

Primary Source: Speech from "What the Black Man Wants," by Frederick Douglass, 1865

Frederick Douglass, sitting next to the table in the photo on the left, was an escaped slave who taught himself to read and write. Douglass became one of the most powerful and outspoken opponents of slavery, and proponents, or supporters, of women's rights. He delivered this speech to the Massachusetts Anti-Slavery Society in 1865.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE Why does Douglass reject the pity and sympathy of other abolitionists?

> I understand the anti-slavery societies of this country to be based on two principles–first, the freedom of the blacks of this country; and, second, the elevation of them. Let me not be misunderstood here. I am not asking for sympathy at the hands of abolitionists, sympathy at the hands of any. What I ask . . . is not benevolence, not pity, not sympathy, but simply justice.

SYNTHESIZE & WRITE

1. **REVIEW** Review what you have learned about 19th-century abolitionists, their ideas and motivations, and their movement.
2. **RECALL** On your own paper, write the main ideas expressed by Garrison, Truth, and Douglass.
3. **CONSTRUCT** Construct a topic sentence that answers this question: In what ways did abolitionists appeal to their fellow citizens' morality in order to gather support to abolish slavery?
4. **WRITE** Using evidence from this chapter and the documents, write an informative paragraph that supports your topic sentence in Step 3.

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